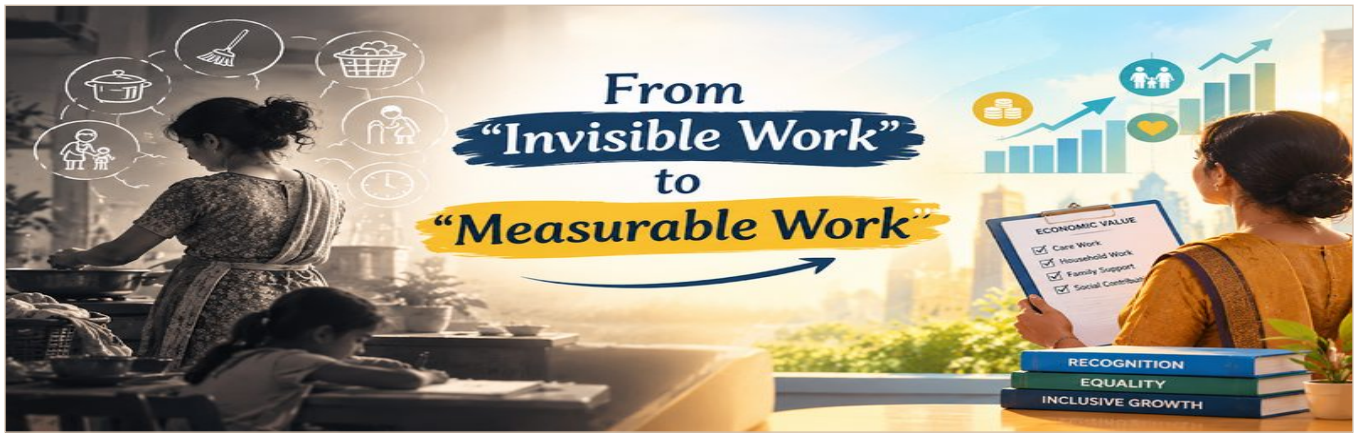


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Founder & Chief Mentor

[GS PAPER I – INDIAN SOCIETY • GS PAPER II – SOCIAL JUSTICE • GS PAPER III – INDIAN ECONOMY • GS PAPER IV – ETHICS • ESSAY]
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From “Invisible Work” to “Measurable Work”



The article explores how unpaid household and care work, often overlooked in economic statistics, contributes significantly to human capital, family welfare and the wider economy. It highlights the Supreme Court’s recognition of “loss of domestic care” as a distinct compensable contribution, marking a shift from “invisible work” to measurable economic value.

From “Invisible Work” to “Measurable Work”

Syllabus areas:

Essay

GS Paper I – Indian Society

GS Paper II – Social Justice

GS Paper III – Indian Economy

GS Paper IV – Ethics

The SC on June 11, 2026 held that unpaid domestic labour performed by Housewives must be assigned an independent economic value while determining compensation in motor accident death cases, **they** are accidents involving motor vehicles—such as cars, buses, trucks, motorcycles, or autorickshaws—that cause **injury, death, or property damage**. It fixed minimum notional income 30000 per month.



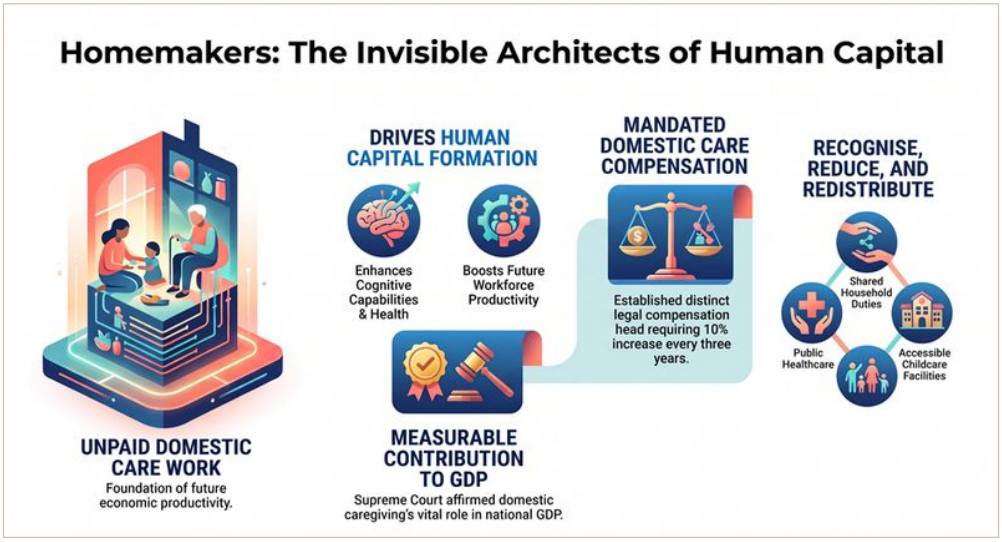
Home makers are Nation builders.



Care work includes childcare, elderly care, supporting persons with disabilities, nutrition, health management and emotional support within households. Though often unpaid and invisible in economic statistics, it directly contributes to **human capital formation** by improving health, education, skills and productivity.

Well-nourished and adequately cared-for children are more likely to develop better cognitive and physical capabilities, perform well in education and become productive members of the workforce. Similarly, care for elderly and dependent persons supports the well-being of the entire household.

Thus, unpaid care work creates a **social and economic foundation for future productivity**. Recognising, reducing and redistributing this work through childcare facilities, healthcare services, social protection and greater sharing of household responsibilities can strengthen both **human capital and inclusive economic growth**.



Created distinct head of compensation called "loss of domestic care" in motor accident claims and mandated a 10% increase in this amount every three years.

The ruling came in an appeal from a motor accident claim in Punjab.

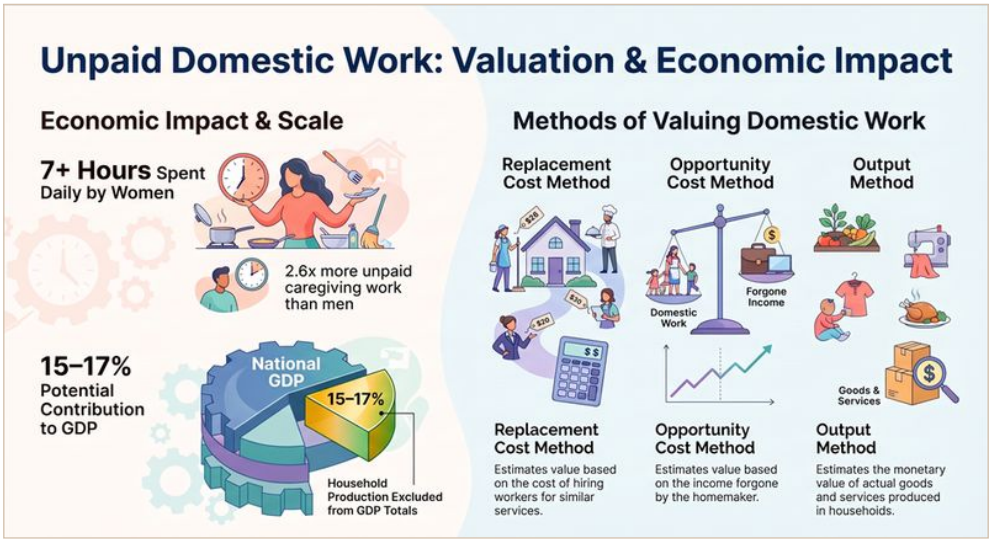
Observing that welfare-oriented objective of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, India’s principal legislation regulating motor vehicles, road transport and traffic. It covers vehicle registration, driving licences, permits, insurance, road safety, offences, penalties and compensation for victims of motor accidents, is frustrated when compensation claims remain pending for years.

SC says – Cooking, cleaning, caregiving etc play vital role in contribution of GDP.

Therefore, Home makers are architects of India's human capital. It recognised unpaid domestic work as a measurable economic contribution.

Methods of Valuing Unpaid Domestic Work:

Unpaid domestic work can be valued through three major methods: **Replacement Cost Method**, which estimates the cost of hiring workers for similar services; **Opportunity Cost Method**, based on income forgone by the homemaker; and **Output Method**, which estimates the monetary value of goods and services produced within the household.



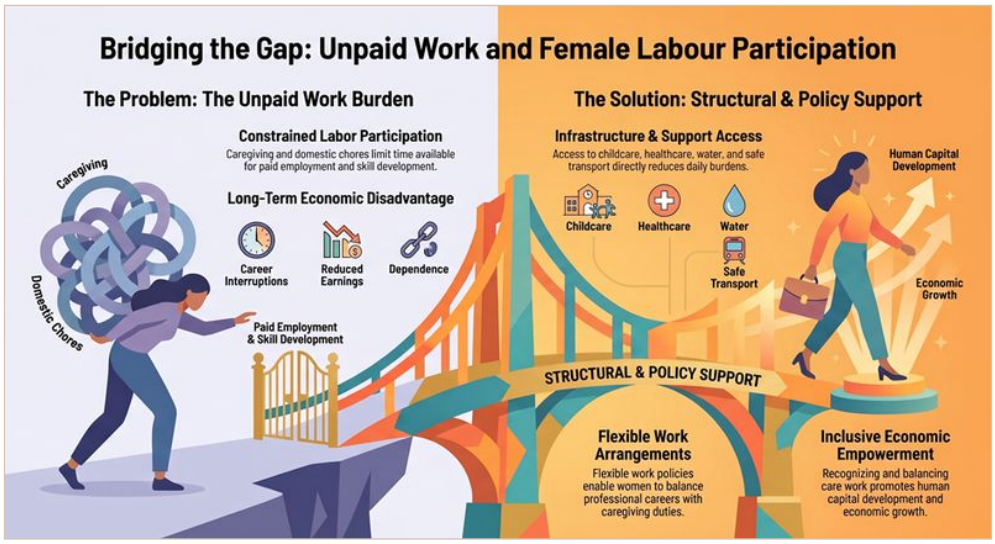
Court noted that women spend over seven hours a day on unpaid domestic tasks, nearly 2.6 times more unpaid caregiving work than men and contribute an estimated 15–17% of India's GDP through this labour. That figure appears nowhere in the national accounts. Conventional GDP measurement excludes household production entirely.

For the life insurance industry, the ruling is an instruction it should act on without waiting for a regulatory directive. The Court limited the home maker definition to women only; if a man does the same, what next? and an unemployed job seeker between placements or yet to enter employment these are also "non-earning woman performing domestic work".

Constitutional Linkages with Homemakers:

Constitutional Article	Link with Homemakers
Article 14	Recognition of homemakers' unpaid work supports equality before law and equal treatment in compensation and social protection.
Article 15	Addresses gender-based disadvantages arising from the traditional unequal distribution of domestic and care responsibilities.
Article 16	Unequal household responsibilities can affect women's access to education, employment and opportunities for economic participation.
Article 21	Recognition of domestic work reinforces the **dignity, autonomy and value** of homemakers' contributions to family and society.
Article 39(a)	Homemakers contribute significantly to the family's livelihood and economic well-being through unpaid domestic and care work.
Article 39(d)	Raises the broader issue of recognising and fairly valuing work traditionally performed by women without monetary remuneration.
Article 42	Supports the need for humane conditions for women, maternity relief, childcare and institutional support for care responsibilities.
Article 43	Connects with the broader objective of ensuring decent living conditions and economic security for women and care workers.

Unpaid Work and Female Labour Force Participation:



The unequal burden of **unpaid domestic and caregiving work** can constrain women’s participation in the formal labour market. Time spent on cooking, cleaning, childcare and elderly care reduces the time available for paid employment, education and skill development. This can contribute to **career interruptions, lower earnings and economic dependence**. Improving access to childcare, healthcare, sanitation, water supply, safe transport and flexible work arrangements can reduce this burden and enable greater workforce participation. Thus, recognising and redistributing unpaid work is important for **women’s economic empowerment, inclusive growth and human capital development**.